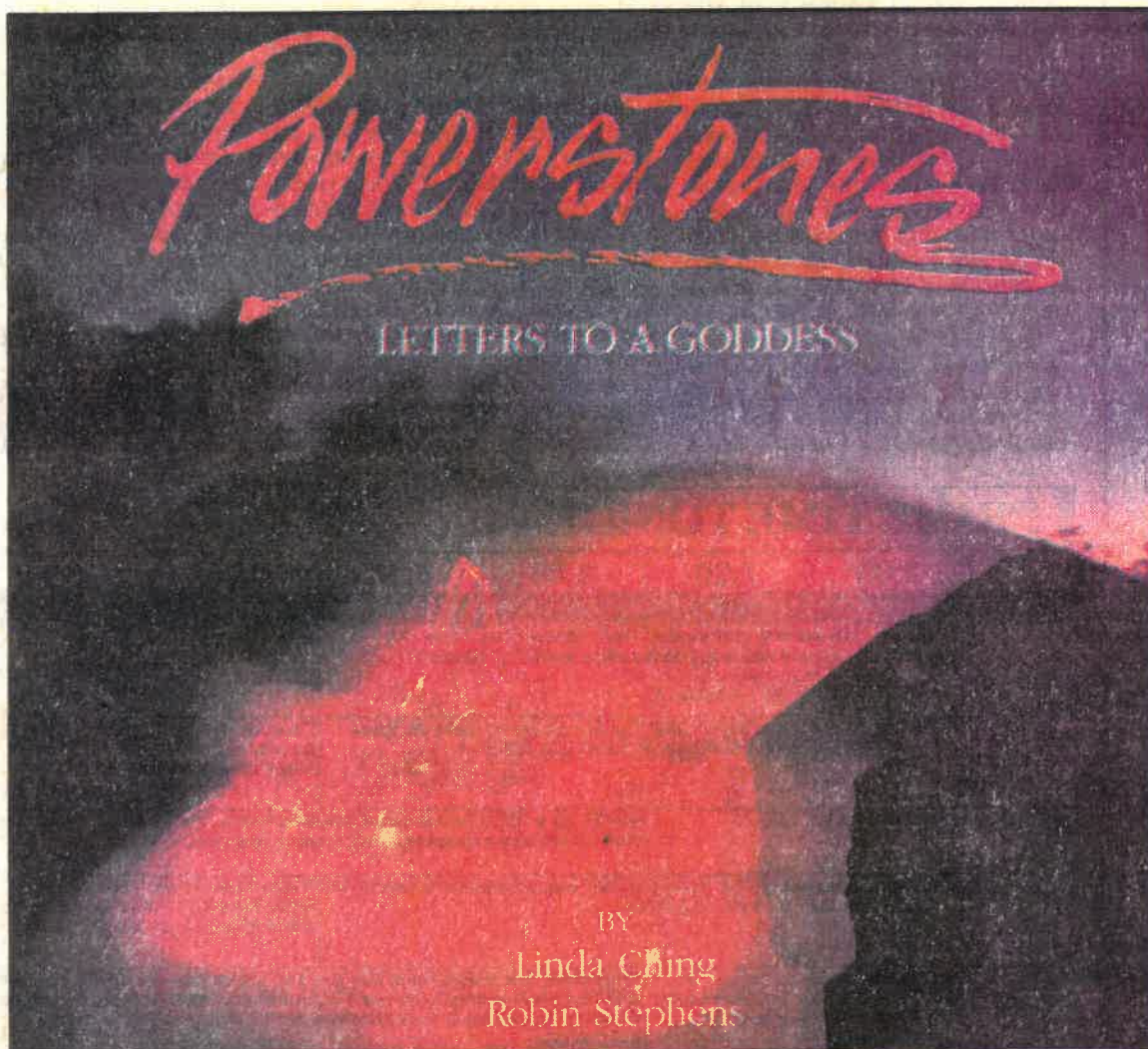


BOOKS



Robin Stephens

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"Powerstones (Letters to a Goddess)" details hardships suffered for, essentially, falling for a hoax.

Time for Pele's curse to take a rest

■ A new book reveals letter writers' 'cursed' lives after they removed lava rocks

BY CHARLES MEMMINGER
 Star-Bulletin

ONE of the more curious things that happens at Hawaii Volcanos National Park is the yearly return of hundreds of pounds lava rocks by people who believe that the rocks have brought down the wrath of the fire goddess Pele upon them.

The rocks are usually accompanied by letters containing detailed accounts of the horrible things that have happened to the rock thieves such as: "Dear Madame Pele, We didn't realize it was taboo to keep lava and that it would make you angry. We certainly have had more than our share of bad luck, and are terribly sorry to have angered you. Please accept these back with our most humble apologies and PLEASE RELEASE THE CURSE."

Author Linda Ching and friend Robin Stephens saw the hundreds of letters as a rich vein of material that could be mined and displayed in a book about the famous "curse" of Pele.

Well, a funny thing happened on the way to literary fame and fortune: Ching and Stephens found out that the "curse" of Pele was nothing more than a hoax started by a volcano park ranger in 1946 to keep tourists from stealing

Powerstones (Letters to a Goddess): by Linda Ching and Robin Stephens, 143 pages, \$25

lava rock from the national park.

The curse is that the hoax has grown and solidified in visitors' minds like a flow of molten lava, resulting in park officials having to deal with tons of rocks every year.

Still convinced there was a book in them—there stones, Ching and Stephens pushed forward with their project, albeit with a few alterations.

"We knew that we had a bigger story here," said Stephens. "I grew up believing the curse ... so I was startled in finding out that there was no basis for it in Hawaiian mythology and folklore."

"We looked at the book in a different way," said Ching. "The fact that 2,000 pounds of rock are returned each year is a serious phenomenon. We decided to use 'curse' as a backdrop to explore minds of extraordinary people."

The result is "Powerstones," one of the more unusual books to be published locally. Unusual, because, it is actually two books. The first part of the book are the letters from the "cursed" rock thieves, begging for forgiveness and laying out their litany of misfortune since absconding with the insidious igneous material.

The second part is a strange collection of inspirational messages from a diverse group that runs from the Dalai Lama to Arnold Palmer.

"We wanted to investigate the nature

of belief," the authors say.

But the danger is that readers interested in the intriguing letters by people convinced that one lousy lava rock ruined their life aren't the same kind of people interested in reading a spiritual half-time pep talk by the Dalai Lama such as: "If you wish to harvest in the fall, you must plant in the spring. Good fortune comes from good deeds. We, therefore, need to take care of our planet as our only home and as our Mother Earth."

Yeah, yeah, yeah. But let's get back to the lady who sent back some black sand to the park because her Toyota was stolen, her husband's father passed out for no apparent reason, her sister and brother-in-law lost their jobs, she strained her back, her mother had a mastectomy, her husband got TB, her sister-in-law got multiple sclerosis and her new Grand Am was stolen. Whew.

Or the person who simply wrote: "We won the \$600,000 lottery. We would have won the \$2,000,000 one if it wasn't for this ... please take the rocks back before more bad luck."

Ching and Stephens are right. There are strange psychological forces at work when people believe they are cursed, when in fact the entire curse is nothing more than a glorified a theft-prevention program.

University of Hawaii philosophy professor Larry Laudan hits the rock on the head in his introduction to "Powerstones": "What the collection of visitor letters at Hawaii Volcanoes National Park shows is that, among the tens of millions of tourists who have

Unearthing 'stones'

"Powerstones" is available at Borders, Liberty House, Honolulu Books, Island Provisions, Martin & MacArthur, Bishop Museum Shop Pacifica and Waldenbooks.

Book signings take place 6 to 9 p.m. Nov. 20 at Liberty House; 11 a.m. to 1 p.m. and 4 to 6 p.m. Nov. 25 and 27 at Mary Philpotts "Christmas Store"; and 11 a.m. to 12:30 p.m. Nov. 26, at Borders.

probably taken home small chunks of the Big Island, a few thousand lived to regret it. The overwhelming majority who stole from Madame Pele presumably are, so far as we know, none the worse for having done so."

The authors inadvertently create a similar situation by including the inspirational tales of "power thinkers, truth seekers and magic makers" who succeeded in life by the power of their beliefs. Professor Laudan might have also asked, "How many people with similarly strong beliefs failed?"

But that may be unfairly throwing stones at an intriguing little book that will appeal to people who like to channel surf between Oprah and the Discovery Channel.

Somewhere in the book is another message, the authors say. It is a plea for people to stop sending rocks back. Park officials, frankly, have had enough of the curse they created. It's put them between a lava rock and a hard place.